

After the Story: They Weren't Metaphors

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A companion study to *Little Gap*

Back to Little Gap

Pull your chair closer. We're going back up Blue Mountain, to a rented cabin above Little Gap, where the Appalachian Trail cuts the ridge and the wind comes hard off the Lehigh.

It's October. The youth group is roasting marshmallows. Somebody at the fire ring says the giants in Genesis were metaphors. Somebody else says they were cartoons for people who hadn't got science yet. Then Mr. Kovacs, the youth pastor's father, the man who still carries a folding rule in his shirt pocket the way other men carry pens, screws the lid on his thermos and says it the way he'd say a rafter was out of square.

"They weren't metaphors."

Then he tells the story the way his father told him, and the way that man's father told him before that. A boy named Adon digs tubers behind a mudbrick house while his father cuts wood in Noah's yard. Tall shining ones walk into the settlement in real bodies. Children grow wrong and then grow huge. Violence fills the valley. A hundred and twenty years tick down on doorposts. Adon grabs his sister's wrist and runs toward the yard, not toward the famous names. Noah stands at a single door and names the Lord. The rain comes. And Mr. Kovacs stops the story where the Book stops it. Eight souls. No invented ninth.

Tonight we're going to sit with that fire and ask what Genesis 6 is asking us to believe.

Questions to Sit With

1. Read Genesis 6:1-4. The kids at Little Gap wanted the giants to be poetry. What does the text actually say walked the earth in those days, and what does it call their fathers?
2. Read Jude 6 and 2 Peter 2:4. Scripture says the angels who left their proper domain are kept for judgment. If the Watchers are under chains, what does that tell you about inviting their kind of voice into your night?

3. Read Genesis 6:3 and Genesis 7:16, then Matthew 24:37 (and Luke 17:26 beside it). God gave a count. God shut a door. Jesus said the days of Noah would look familiar again. What is the brave move when the count is running?

The Teaching: They Left Their Post

Start where Mr. Kovacs started. The tall ones walked.

Genesis does not open chapter 6 with a parable about big egos. It says men multiplied, daughters were born, and the sons of God saw those daughters and took them (Genesis 6:1-2). The children of those unions were the Nephilim, the giants, the mighty ones of old, men of renown (Genesis 6:4). Rick Renner takes that reading at full weight in *Fallen Angels, Giants, Monsters and the World Before the Flood*. He writes of the "inconceivable activities of the fallen angels and their hybrid offspring the Bible calls giants" (Renner, ch. 5). He says "these hybrid beings were physically enormous, possessed unnatural strength, and propagated evil and violence throughout the earth in the time before the Flood" (Renner, ch. 5). That is Adon at the market, watching a boy already the height of a grown man flatten a copper bracelet in the mud without looking down. Renown, the neighbors called it. Gift, they called it. Adon's father called it theft.

Who were the sons of God? Renner follows the old line, the one Job uses when the sons of God present themselves before the Lord (Job 1:6; 2:1; 38:7). They were angelic beings. Ancient writers called them Watchers, "God-assigned watchers over mankind who became derelict in their assignment" (Renner, ch. 3). Renner's own sentence for what they did is as plain as Mr. Kovacs's thermos lid: "disobedient, mutinous angels abandoned their God-assigned posts, descended into the earth's atmosphere, and began to sexually defile mortal women, who produced hybrid offspring as a result of that unholy, unauthorized union" (Renner, ch. 4). Adon's father said the same thing over supper with pitch still on his forearms. They were set to watch. They wanted the daughters instead.

Hold that against the soft readings you hear around a campfire when kids want to sound grown. The Sethite view, the idea that Genesis 6 is only about godly boys marrying ungodly girls, does not carry the weight of the words. Renner lays out why. Nearly every time Scripture says "sons of God," it is talking about angelic beings. The daughters of men are mankind's daughters, not a

rival clan. And Jude and Peter do not waste ink on a marriage counseling problem in Seth's family tree. They write about angels who left their proper domain.

That is the second hard stone in this story. The Watchers are judged. Jude says the angels who did not keep their own position, but left their proper dwelling, are kept in eternal chains under darkness for the judgment of the great day (Jude 6). Peter says God did not spare angels when they sinned, but cast them into a place of detention and committed them to chains of darkness to be kept until judgment (2 Peter 2:4). Renner will not let you turn that prison into a myth. "Peter unequivocally stated it is a real detention center where God has incarcerated the rebellious angels who sinned in Genesis 6:1,2, and 4" (Renner, ch. 4). So when we teach this tale, we do not invite anybody to call those voices up, bargain with them, or treat them like counselors with bad manners. They left their post on purpose. Scripture says they are kept for judgment. Adon named the Lord on the path. He did not ask the shining ones for a word.

Then the hunger. Genesis says the earth was corrupt and filled with violence, and all flesh had corrupted its way (Genesis 6:11-12). Renner puts the giants in that sentence with both feet: "hybrid giants were born that brought widespread bloodshed and violence into the period before the Flood" (Renner, ch. 7). That is the spear through the headman's door. That is fields stripped in a week. That is why Noah's hammer kept time while scoffers at the fence cheered the famous names.

And still, God gave time. Genesis 6:3 is a count, not a shrug. Renner hears it as mercy with a clock on it. God "gave them the space of 120 years to repent" (Renner, ch. 8). Noah built and preached through that span, and Renner says, "Every swing of his hammer was a prophetic proclamation of a timeline that would eventually reach an end" (Renner, ch. 8). Adon scratched seasons under his sleeping shelf. Old men scratched doorposts. The Lord was grieved down to His heart (Genesis 6:6). The years still ran.

When the door comes into view, keep the story honest the way Mr. Kovacs kept it honest. Renner notes there was "only one way into the Ark, and it was through the single door God designed as the entrance" (Renner, ch. 11). Genesis says the Lord shut him in (Genesis 7:16). The Book names eight souls (Genesis 7:7, 7:13; 1 Peter 3:20; 2 Peter 2:5). Renner says the same: "God ultimately found only one family of eight (Noah and his wife, their three sons, and their sons' wives) to be free of the corruption that had affected the entire rest of the human race"

(Renner, ch. 3). Adon ran the right direction. Whether his family went through that door is the knife Mr. Kovacs left on the stone. A wise teller does not invent a ninth passenger Scripture forgot. The frame is a campfire tale that drives you back to the Book. The Book's boarding list stays the Book's boarding list.

Last, listen to Jesus. He said the coming of the Son of Man would be as the days of Noah were (Matthew 24:37; Luke 17:26). Renner hears a hard echo in those words. He writes that "those living at the end of the age will experience a replication of what was occurring before the Great Deluge that was released on the earth in the days of Noah" (Renner, ch. 14). Under a pine, that does not turn into a chart on the cabin wall. It turns into the same choice Adon made with his sister's wrist in his hand. Run toward the yard. Keep your eyes on the seam. Name the Lord. Let the famous names shout at the fence without you.

The veil gets thin in places people stop expecting. Giants are not a metaphor you outgrow. Watchers left their domain once already. Earth has been through one cleansing of that particular evil. The hammer still keeps time for anybody with ears.

Around the Fire: Talk It Over and Take It Home

Talk about the fire ring at your own church, or the lunch table, or the group chat where somebody laughed Genesis 6 off as outdated. Say out loud what you used to do with that chapter. Then ask what changes if the tall ones really walked. Renner and Mr. Kovacs are on the same side of that question. Softening the text into poetry will not make the violence in it go away.

Talk about Adon's two moves. He named the Lord, and he ran toward the yard. Which one comes harder for you when fear shows up tall? Some of us want to stand and argue with every scoffer at the fence. Some of us want to freeze and watch the famous names. Adon kept his sister's wrist and his father's Name and his feet moving.

Talk about the unanswered boarding. It is all right not to know if Adon's family made the eight. Scripture did not appoint us to pad the passenger list. What Scripture did give us is a door, a count, a judgment on the Watchers, and a warning from Jesus that the days of Noah will look familiar again. That is enough wood for one fire.

Try this, this week. Read Genesis 6 out loud, slow, without a study note in your hand the first time through. Then read Jude 6 and 2 Peter 2:4 and write one sentence in your own words about what God did with angels who left their post. Learn Matthew 24:37 by heart as a paraphrase you can say under a pine: as it was in the days of Noah, so it will be when the Son of Man comes. If a voice, a feed, or a "game" ever invites you to chat up the other side of the veil, shut it down. Those posts were abandoned on purpose, and the ones who abandoned them are kept for judgment. Put another oak on. Keep the light high enough to show you the pines are trees. And when the count is running, run the right direction.

Works Cited

Renner, Rick. *Fallen Angels, Giants, Monsters and the World Before the Flood*. Shippensburg, PA: Harrison House, 2024.